introduced to the game.

But his reflexes, his hand–eye coordination, his natural flair and aggression – it was unbelievable. It was also very frustrating for us, the way he could move, just pick the ball and scoop it – either out of the park or right into the hands of mid-on. Yes, he struggled in the Test era, but once the age of T20s began, there was no looking back. It was a format tailormade for him.

Afridi wasn't limited by any means. But he limited himself. At the international level, if you believe that you don't have what it takes, then you will not produce what is required of you. You need to believe in yourself. You have to set boundaries: 'I will leave the short ball, I will defend outside off stump.' You must follow the basic rules. Afridi, it was proved over time, is just human.

I didn't approve of his starts and stops. For example, the way he quit captaincy in 2010 after leading Pakistan in just one Test. It showed that he hadn't thought the plan through. Today, if you want to be a known quantity, you must be someone who's in it for the long-term.

But no matter what Afridi has achieved and despite his retirement from the Pakistan side, stadiums fill up for him even today when he plays limited-overs formats. He is an impact player. A cricketer for any era. He is a star. I wasn't sure about his charisma in the early days, though. By 1999, I realized it was there. The aura around him was building.

I remember a match against Zimbabwe. We had a packed stadium in Peshawar. Absolutely chock-a-block. There were more people outside the stadium than there were inside. The crowd was going nuts, screaming his name. He came in, pulled a high one, it came off his glove and he was caught, first ball. The crowd went nuts and attempted to break the gates – they wanted him to have another go. They said it was a 'try ball', like it was a street match. The cops had to come in with water cannons and tear gas. It's remarkable that Afridi had that star power just a couple of years into the Pakistan team.

The crucial thing about Afridi is that everything he does and doesn't do works. Sure, he's got an image. He's a fit guy. He's got the looks. And I'm so proud of the work he's done for the Shahid Afridi Foundation.

But you don't just become a star. You must be aware of what's going on around you too. I tried to learn. I still do. You live it up, sure, but you have to know your stuff too.

Was he easy to lead? Yes. Was he there when the team needed him? Yes. Was he up for taking the pressure? Yes. Up for any tough fielding position? Always. No hesitation. Not even for a moment. Afridi was as brave as a warrior. He is one of the strongest men I've known. It's been said that he has a problem with authority. Fine, but only with authority which is not worth respecting. You have to know his psyche to lead him. He is not stubborn at all. You must know what you're dealing with. If he respects you, he will put his life on the firing line for you.

Sure, it was a treat to have him, and I enjoyed leading him. I took it as a challenge. Saqlain Mushtaq, Abdul Razzaq, Azhar Mahmood, Shoaib Akhtar, Shahid Afridi – when all of them were in the same playing eleven, especially in the shorter format, it made the Pakistan team invincible.

But as a captain, nobody kept me on edge more than Afridi did. One couldn't even go to the loo when he was playing in the middle. That's because he could change any game, anytime. He was and will remain a game changer.